

INTRODUCTION

Child Rights and You (CRY) firmly believes that every child deserves a safe, protected, and nurturing environment to grow and thrive. In alignment with the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child, CRY's Child Safeguarding Policy (CSP) is a comprehensive framework designed to prevent abuse, neglect, and exploitation of children across all its programs and partnerships. This policy reflects CRY's zero-tolerance approach towards any harm to children and emphasizes dignity, equality, and child participation at its core. The policy outlines specific roles, responsibilities, and preventive measures for staff, partners, volunteers, and visitors, ensuring child protection is upheld in every interaction. Through structured risk assessment, ethical media practices, informed consent, online safety protocols, and rigorous recruitment processes, CRY aims to build a culture of accountability and child-centricity. This presentation highlights the key components, procedures, and commitments embedded in the policy to ensure every child's safety and well-being remains the top priority.

REFERENCE GUID FOR STATUTORY COMPLIANCES

CRY's Child Safeguarding Policy affirms that every child has the right to a happy, healthy, and creative childhood. The organization strongly upholds zero tolerance for any form of abuse, violence, neglect, or exploitation against children. This policy has been designed to reinforce CRY's commitment towards child protection, ensuring that children's safety and welfare are always prioritized. It aims to establish clear protective mechanisms within all CRY initiatives, define standard conduct for staff and associates, and build awareness and preparedness among all individuals working with or for children. A child is defined as any person under the age of 18, based on the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child. Child abuse includes physical, emotional, and sexual harm, neglect, and exploitation, whether by deliberate actions or failure to act. Child protection means taking all necessary measures to prevent such harm. The policy applies to all CRY staff, including part-time, contractual, volunteers, interns, project partners, vendors, donors, and visitors. Informed consent, either written or verbal, is mandatory before taking a child's photograph, video, or sharing their story, and the child's right to say 'no' must be respected.

CRY's guiding principles emphasize non-discrimination, the dignity and respect of all children, the prioritization of their best interests, and the encouragement of their meaningful participation. These principles ensure that children's voices are heard, and their safety is maintained in all engagements.

CONTINUING...

Code of Conduct, Responsibilities, Reporting & Response

CRY requires that all staff, associates, and visitors uphold the highest standards of behavior when interacting with children. They must always respect the privacy and dignity of children, ensure that proper consent is taken before any interviews or media recordings, maintain professional boundaries in communication, and ensure that images of children used in any medium are appropriate, dignified, and respectful. Individuals must avoid any behavior that could be seen as abusive, inappropriate, or offensive, including verbal, physical, or online contact that breaches trust or invades privacy. They are prohibited from sharing children's personal information, contacting them socially without authorization, taking them to private spaces, or providing gifts outside approved programs.

The organization ensures awareness through training, induction, and accessible documentation. Preventive measures include safe recruitment practices, partner agreements that uphold CRY's child protection standards, and strict adherence to national child protection laws. Reporting of any suspected or confirmed abuse is mandatory and must be done within 24 hours to the designated authority or CRY leadership. Reports should include details of the incident and maintain confidentiality. CRY commits to a timely response-initiating action within 48 hours-and follows a structured investigation process while respecting legal obligations.

CRY appoints a Designated Authority (DA) to oversee policy implementation and compliance. The organization stresses that ignorance of the law is not an excuse, and every individual associated with CRY is expected to comply with the policy both professionally and personally.

PHOTOGRAPHY AND VIDEOGRAPHY

This SOP outlines child safeguarding guidelines for photography, videography, interviews, and media reporting to protect children's privacy, dignity, and well-being. It emphasizes respectful representation, avoiding images that expose children to harm or violate their rights. Sensitive issues like child marriage, labour, or abuse must never reveal identities; fictional names and stock images should be used with disclaimers. Consent is critical — informed permission from children and guardians is mandatory, especially for those over 14. Children must understand the context, and no financial inducement is allowed for participation. Group consent is acceptable for public gatherings, but individual consent is needed for identifiable portrayals. Photographers must avoid geo-tagging and use secure storage, with images accessible only to authorized personnel. External agents must assign rights to CRY, follow the child safeguarding policy (CSP), and be accompanied by CRY staff. Interviews must be consented to, never spontaneous, and conducted with care to prevent distress or re-victimization. Support must be provided to prepare families and children, and refusals must be respected. Overall, child safety, privacy, and dignity must be prioritized at every step in documentation and storytelling

READY RECKONER/CHECKLIST FOR USAGE OF PHOTOGRAPHY/FILMS AND CASE STORIES

Informed consent must be obtained from both the child and their parent or guardian before any photography, filming, or interviews. Without a signed consent form, stories or photographs cannot be used. No incentives should be offered for consent. For success stories without sensitive backgrounds, real first names and general locations (e.g., district and state) can be used. Stories involving child labour, trafficking, abuse, etc., must use neutral pseudo names and blurred photos to protect identity, with a separate log maintained. Children must be portrayed respectfully, and such documentation should occur in the presence of a trusted adult. For individuals above 18, similar guidelines apply, including the right to withdraw consent at any time, which must be respected by removing content from public platforms. Personal social media sharing of such stories and images is not allowed; only organizational platforms may be used for dissemination.

WORKING WITH CHILD ACTORS

This protocol governs the engagement of child actors (under 18 years) in audio-visual content produced or commissioned by CRY for branding, awareness, or fundraising.

These children may be professional performers or participants from local organizations. The content can be distributed on platforms such as Facebook, Twitter, WhatsApp, and CRY's websites. Under the Child and Adolescent Labour (Prohibition and Regulation) Act and Rules 2017, Children can work a maximum of five hours a day, with no more than three hours without a break. Permission must be obtained from the District Magistrate, accompanied by a form with guardian consent, and the name of a responsible adult. This adult ensures the safety and well-being of each child during the production. The form remains valid for six months and must provide provisions for health, safety, education, protection against abuse. At least 20% of the child's income must be deposited into a fixed account in a nationalized bank, which they can access in adulthood. Children must not be forced to participate. No child is allowed to work overtime. Shoots must include breaks, ideally every hour, with nutritious food, drinking water, separate bathrooms for boys and girls. A parent or guardian must accompany each child.

CHILD PROTECTION IN ORGANIZING EVENTS

Events involving children should be relevant to their age and needs, with clearly defined goals and roles. Children must be informed about the nature and purpose of the event, and involved in planning when possible. Proper planning, including child protection risk assessments at different stages, is essential. Parental consent and detailed information about the child, including medical and emergency contacts, must be collected. Venues should be legally compliant, safe, and equipped with essential facilities like toilets, water, food, lighting, and fire safety. Safe travel arrangements, appropriate escort-to-child ratios, and trained volunteers are necessary. Entry, exit, and emergency plans must be clear and communicated. In public hearings, sensitive cases must be assessed carefully, ensuring the psychological safety of children.

Parental/child consent is required, and identifying details must be kept confidential. Media and panelists should follow child protection norms, and care must be taken to avoid any form of stigma or harm to the child.

RISK ASSESSMENT FRAMEWORK

An effective child safeguarding policy includes a structured approach to periodic risk assessment and management across all programs and spaces involving children. Risk assessment refers to the methodical evaluation of potential harm, abuse, or hazards that may affect children. This process is context-specific and aims to identify, minimize, or eliminate risks. It must be applied whenever a new child-related program or event is planned and periodically reviewed in ongoing programs. Risks are grouped into five key parameters: Infrastructure, Personnel, Program Activity, Information, and Organizational Culture. Each of these areas can pose various threats, such as physical hazards in infrastructure (e.g., sharp furniture, fire risks), risks from personnel (e.g., unvented staff or volunteers), program-related dangers (e.g., dehydration or physical injury), information misuse (e.g., mishandling personal data), and unsafe organizational practices (e.g., lack of transparency). The risk assessment process involves several steps:

1. Identifying potential sub-factors under each parameter.
2. Recognizing specific hazards and the likelihood of abuse.
3. Considering the vulnerability of different children
4. Ranking risks as low, medium, or high based on severity and likelihood.
5. Managing identified risks through appropriate actions—ranging from doing nothing (if risk is low), monitoring, modifying procedures, or stopping the activity altogether for high risks

All stakeholders, including children, must participate in the assessment process to ensure diverse perspectives on what constitutes risk. The ultimate goal is to ensure child safety by proactively addressing potential threats within any child-centric space or program. CRY's Risk Assessment format requires detailing the context, date, and specific risks under each category, identifying who may be affected, and documenting measures taken to mitigate those risks.

ONLINE SAFETY OF CHILDREN

This SOP outlines guidelines for the safe and respectful online participation of children representing the organization in events, webinars, and educational classes. It emphasizes confidentiality, especially for children from vulnerable backgrounds (e.g., child labor, abuse). Children must not share identifying information beyond their first name and district. Informed consent from guardians is mandatory, and children must be oriented about event objectives, expectations, and online etiquette. Events should be by invitation only, with strict Zoom controls (e.g., waiting room, no screen sharing). For online classes, contact must be limited to scheduled times, with no social media interaction between volunteers and children. Children should log in via organizational accounts or devices, use neutral backgrounds, and dress modestly. Digital literacy is crucial—children should be educated about privacy, social media risks, and reporting threats. Volunteers must avoid introducing unfamiliar apps without consultation and must always prioritize the child's safety. Any violation of child protection must be reported to appropriate authorities, including partner organizations and CRY teams.

HUMAN RESOURCE

The recruitment and selection process must ensure candidates are aware of CRY's or its partners' commitment to Child Protection (CP) and have no history of CP violations, verified through reference checks. Job advertisements should require resumes, photographs, and at least two referees. Interviews must probe gaps in employment history. Reference checks must include specific questions on CP and be documented. Appointed candidates must submit identity, address, education, and work proofs, and receive a signed appointment letter detailing employment conditions and a copy of the Child Safeguarding Policy (CSP). They must sign and return the appointment letter and CSP commitment form. Personnel records must include all relevant documents and contact details. Induction programs should cover CSP, roles, and responsibilities, followed by periodic CP training based on assessed needs. Child protection must be part of all training needs assessments. Disciplinary action for CP violations should align with the organization's standing orders and redressal mechanisms in the CSP.

PARTNERSHIP AND ASSOCIATES

The Child Safeguarding Policy (CSP) is integral to CRY's program partnerships and applies to all stakeholders engaging with children through CRY's programs. A partner organization's child protection orientation is assessed during the selection process and incorporated into the pre-funding diligence report. Partner agreements must include a CSP adherence clause, with standards not lower than CRY's. CSP implementation follows a phased approach: Year 1 ensures CRY project staff adherence and basic redressive mechanisms; Year 2 focuses on capacity building and monitoring; Year 3 expects full partner adherence. Violations by partner staff may lead to suspension or termination, especially if serious or unaddressed by leadership. CRY may file an FIR in legal violation cases. Vendors, consultants, and service providers in contact with children must comply with CSP, and contracts must reflect this. CRY will not contract entities engaging in child labor. Donors must follow CSP during visits, use of media, and in publications. Alliances/networks supported by CRY must adhere to CSP, and visitors must be informed of the code of conduct and accompanied during child interactions. Children are actively involved in protection efforts through awareness, reporting training, and child-friendly CSP displays in program areas. CRY ensures children understand their rights and reporting mechanisms for effective safeguarding.

STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURE- INTERNAL AND EXTERNAL REPORTING PROCESS

CRY's Child Safeguarding Policy (CSP) outlines clear internal and external reporting procedures for child protection concerns. The internal reporting process applies to incidents involving CRY staff or associates and ensures prompt action within 24 hours, with assessments, investigations, and follow-ups led by designated authorities. Actions may include suspension, internal/criminal investigations, and reporting to police. Confidentiality and support for affected individuals are emphasized. For external cases—those occurring in CRY program areas but not involving CRY personnel—the response includes reporting to child protection authorities, childlines, or local police within five working days. CRY representatives are expected to act according to national child protection laws. Outcomes include legal reporting, referrals to support services, and risk assessments. An example involving inappropriate behavior by a staff member highlights how disclosures are addressed promptly and sensitively. Both reporting mechanisms aim to ensure children's safety while upholding accountability, transparency, and the legal obligations of all CRY representatives.

VOLUNTEER AND INTERN ONBOARDING VIS A VIS CSP

This document outlines CRY's child protection and volunteer engagement protocols. When an adolescent girl reports stalking or sexual harassment by a youth in a CRY intervention area, the disclosure must be reported within 24 hours to the CRY NGO partner's Child Protection focal point or management. A team meeting will decide further action, with possible outcomes including reporting to statutory authorities, police, or referral services. Risk assessment and confidentiality are key, with follow-up support provided. Volunteer onboarding includes an orientation session covering CRY's Child Protection Policy, code of conduct, and registration requirements. Volunteers/interns working with children must attend detailed child protection sessions and adhere to defined roles, reporting structures, and safety guidelines. Special permissions are required for taking children's photographs, with strict review and sharing protocols. Volunteers must sign a consent form, with parental consent obtained for children participating in events or appearing in media. Photography is restricted to designated personnel, and all media use must comply with CRY norms. Volunteers must provide reference letters, which may be verified by the admin team. These processes aim to ensure child safety, compliance with legal norms, and ethical volunteer conduct in all CRY-related programs.

CONCLUSION

In conclusion, CRY's Child Safeguarding Policy reflects its unwavering commitment to the protection, dignity, and rights of every child associated with its programs. It outlines clear procedures for reporting any incidents of abuse or harassment, ensuring that children are heard and supported without delay. The involvement of designated authorities, timely risk assessments, and appropriate referrals further strengthen the response mechanism. CRY also places strong emphasis on volunteer and intern orientation, making it mandatory for all individuals engaging with children to understand and adhere to child protection norms. By implementing detailed guidelines for consent, photography, and media usage, CRY ensures respect for children's privacy and dignity. Furthermore, the policy stresses continuous supervision, code of conduct monitoring, and follow-up actions to maintain a safe environment. The inclusion of reference checks and consent protocols indicates the organization's proactive approach in preventing harm before it occurs. CRY's holistic framework ensures that both preventive and responsive actions are in place, aligning with national laws and international standards. Ultimately, this policy safeguards not only the physical and emotional well-being of children but also fosters a culture of accountability and care among all staff, volunteers, and stakeholders involved in CRY's mission to uphold child rights.